PARTNERS of the AMERICAS
Connect • Serve • Change Lives

Education and Culture Program

DFOP0017214

FY 2025 Proposal
Submitted on Monday, September 15, 2025

Presented to:
U.S. Department of State
Bureau of Educational and Cultural Affairs
2200 C Street NW, Washington, DC 20037

Submitted by:
Partners of the Americas
1424 K Street NW Suite 700
Washington, DC 20005

Contact:
Carmen S. Peña
Senior Vice President, Programs
cpena@partners.net

Table of Contents

Acronyms **2**

Executive Summary **3**

Program Description **4**

Program Goals and Objectives *4*

Program Activities *7*

Individual Self-Designed Exchanges 9

Group, Pre-designed Exchanges 10

Exchange Participant Support 11

Community-Led Projects 12

Subawards - Group Pre-Designed Exchanges and Community-Led Projects 13

Program Workplan and Marketing *14*

Lessons Learned, Improved Productivity, and Innovations **17**

Lessons Learned *17*

Innovations *18*

Institutional Capacity & Management Plan **19**

Institutional Capacity *19*

Key Personnel *21*

Performance Monitoring Plan (PMP) *21*

Annexes **24**

Acronyms

POA	Partners of the Americas
E&C	Education and Culture Program
LAC	Latin America and the Caribbean
DOS	U.S. Department of State
ECA	Bureau of Educational and Cultural Affairs
NGOs	Non-Governmental Organizations
MODE	Monitoring Data for ECA
SMART	Specific, Measurable, Achievable, Relevant, and Time-bound
PAS	Public Affairs Sector
ASPE	Accident and Sickness Program for Exchanges
AD	Associate Director
F&A	Finance and Administration
GAAP	U.S. Generally Accepted Accounting Principles
PMP	Performance Monitoring Plan
MELI	Monitoring, Evaluation, Learning, and Innovation

Executive Summary

Grounded in the mission of Partners of the Americas (POA)—founded in 1964 under the U.S. Government's Alliance for Progress to connect people and organizations across borders—the Education and Culture (E&C) Program advances the goals of the Mutual Educational and Cultural Exchange Act of 1961 (Public Law 87-256) by fostering mutual understanding and strengthening community-based ties between the United States and Latin America and the Caribbean (LAC). POA proposes to implement the E&C Program in the United States and up to 31 eligible LAC countries over an 18-month period, beginning upon award signature.

The FY 2025 Program goals are: (1) to strengthen the professional skills and global perspectives of emerging and established leaders through project funding and people-to-people exchanges; and (2) Support safer, stronger, and more prosperous communities across the Western Hemisphere by increasing the participation of participants and alumni throughout program planning and implementation, focusing on DOS foreign policy priorities, including agriculture, citizen security, economic success, education, STEM, and cross-cultural understanding.

The program equips volunteers, educators, civic leaders, entrepreneurs, and nonprofit professionals with tools to address shared challenges through exchange and collaboration. Activities will include 20 exchange participants—approximately four (4) through Individual Self-Designed Exchanges and 16 through Group Pre-Designed Exchanges. Three (3) community-led projects will also be supported through sub-awards to member organizations within the POA network. As the United States approaches its Semiquincentennial, the E&C Program will contribute to the America250 celebration by highlighting American innovation, entrepreneurship, and civic exchange through initiatives and success stories that underscore how 250 years of U.S. leadership continue to inspire stronger, safer, and more prosperous communities. POA is requesting $244,129 from the Department of State's Bureau of Educational and Cultural Affairs (ECA) and will contribute $73,870 in cost share, for a total program budget of $315,909.

Program Description

Program Goals and Objectives

With more than 60 years as a partner of the U.S. Department of State, Partners of the Americas (POA) brings a proven institutional framework and hemispheric reach to the Education and Culture (E&C) Program. Building on decades of experience managing exchanges and subawards, POA leverages its regional network to strengthen the capacity of volunteers, educators, civic leaders, NGOs, and entrepreneurs across the United States and Latin America and the Caribbean (LAC).

The E&C Program supports the goals of the Mutual Educational and Cultural Exchange Act of 1961 (Public Law 87-256) by fostering mutual understanding and equipping communities to address shared challenges through people-to-people exchanges and project-based collaboration. The program's three components: (1) Individual Self-Designed Exchanges, (2) Group Pre-Designed Exchanges, and (3) Community-Led Projects generate a multiplier effect by seeding cross-border relationships that expand professional networks, build workforce and STEM capacity, and strengthen long-term institutional and community ties.

Table 1: Impact of the FY23 Education and Culture Program

Activity	Outcome
Exchanges	• 22 northbound participants traveled from Brazil, Bolivia, Colombia, Ecuador, Honduras, Jamaica, Peru, and Venezuela • Eight (8) southbound participants traveled to Argentina, Brazil, Bolivia, El Salvador, Honduras, Peru, and Uruguay • 90% felt more confident in making a difference locally and globally. • 100% reported personal and professional skill growth such as leadership, communication, and problem-solving. • 100% of non-U.S. participants listed more favorable views of American people due to the exchange program.
Projects	• Five (5) projects across eight (8) nations (Argentina, Chile, Colombia, Haiti, Honduras, Nicaragua, the U.S. and Puerto Rico) • 368 people engaged in project activities • 56 workshops over six (6) months • $41,999.86 in E&C project funding and $57,640.42 in localsupport.

Programming for FY 2025 reflects U.S. foreign policy priorities and the Monitoring Data for ECA (MODE) Framework to ensure relevance, sustainability, and measurable outcomes.

Activities will build on POA's strengths in citizen security, economic success, education, and STEM to advance U.S. goals of safer, stronger, and more prosperous communities by promoting innovation, workforce readiness, community security, and regional leadership. The E&C Program will also celebrate American excellence as part of the America250 commemoration through cultural exchange and participant stories of innovation, creativity, and civic engagement.

The goals, activities, and outcomes of the E&C program are designed to reflect the current policy priorities of the U.S. Department of State while leveraging POA's long-standing network and institutional knowledge. Programming will remain flexible and responsive to evolving needs across the hemisphere, with an emphasis on sustainability and participant-led impact. More information on measuring the success and impact of these activities is provided in the Monitoring and Evaluation section. The table below outlines the FY 2025 Education and Culture Program goals, activities, and anticipated outcomes, aligned with ECA priorities and the MODE Framework.

FY25 Education and Culture Program	
E&C Goal 1	**ECA MODE Objectives**
Strengthen the professional skills and global perspectives of emerging and established U.S. and foreign leaders and organizations through project funding and people-to-people exchanges.	Objective 2: Increase the impact that participants and alumni have on their communities / countries. Objective 4: Strengthen personal, professional, and technical abilities and aptitudes of participants and beneficiaries.
Activities	**Anticipated Outcomes**
Activity 1.1: By month 17 of the award, approximately 20 individuals will participate in exchanges (self-designed or pre-designed) addressing shared challenges in areas such as economic opportunity, education, citizen security, and STEM.	• Participants gain practical experience and tools to address shared priorities in their home communities. • Participants report increased understanding of international perspectives. • Participants share personal experiences that amplify U.S. public diplomacy goals.
Activity 1.2: By month 2 of the award, launch five (5) sub-awards: two for group pre-designed exchanges and three for community-led projects responding to shared hemispheric challenges.	• Participating Chapters and organizations expand their ability to deliver impactful projects with U.S. support. • Projects contribute to practical solutions and learning that can be shared across the network.
E&C Goal 2	**ECA MODE Objectives**
Support safer, stronger, and more prosperous communities across the Western Hemisphere by increasing the participation of community members and alumni throughout program planning and implementation, focusing on DOS foreign policy priorities, including economic opportunity, education, citizen security, and STEM.	Objective 1: Advance participant and beneficiary cross-cultural competence and global perspective. Objective 2: Increase the impact that participants and alumni have on their communities / countries. Objective 3: Strengthen engagement among participants, alumni, beneficiaries, and institutions.
Activities	**Anticipated Outcomes**
Activity 2.1: Facilitate engagement opportunities for applicants, participants, and alumni, including communications, feedback, and ongoing connection points.	• Alumni maintain active involvement in programming and mentoring. • Applicants better understand and prepare for program opportunities. • Returning participants receive structured support for reflection and reintegration.
Activity 2.2: POA will build volunteer review committees for selection of awardees, engaging alumni and partners with a range of professional and regional backgrounds.	• Applicants and reviewers see program processes as transparent and participatory. • Alumni strengthen their connection to the network and develop leadership skills.
Activity 2.3: POA will deliver capacity-building support to Chapters and organizational members to strengthen planning, recruitment, and implementation skills. These efforts will promote self-sufficiency and local ownership, informed by participant and alumni feedback, and result in practical tools tailored to on-the-ground needs.	• Chapters and local partners increase their ability to independently design and manage effective exchange and project activities. • Co-created tools and shared practices enhance sustainability, replication, and peer learning. • Participating organizations report increased confidence and readiness to engage in future exchanges or manage external funding.

Program Activities

POA proposes implementing **three (3)** key activities to maximize opportunities for individuals and organizations to work together across borders, build mutual understanding, and increase professional capacity in priority areas (Goal 1): individual self-designed exchanges, group pre-designed exchanges, and community-led projects. POA remains open to adapting thematic areas based on ECA priorities. Proposed themes for FY205 are:

- **Citizen Security**
- **Economic Success**
- **Education**
- **STEM**

"During this exchange, several key professional takeaways emerged. Conducting workshops on AI in education and algorithmic transparency gave me valuable insights into how technology can enhance public sector transparency and improve teaching methodologies. The engagement with English as a Foreign Language teachers in Cochabamba and local educators in Chiclayo highlighted the growing need for integrating AI and digital tools in pedagogical practices."

- Nicolás Arízaga (Colorado, U.S. to Peru and Bolivia)

POA will also underscore the need to include aspects of our organization's three pillars: partnerships, volunteerism, and locally led development by working with POA's geographic and multi-sector network (Chapters and higher education institutional and organizational members). Program components engage stakeholders to foster community connections and in-kind support to ensure success and long-lasting impact. The network is a community of over 75 Chapters and organizational members with interest, experience and expertise in personal and professional growth in community service, volunteerism, civic engagement, international development, and networking with like-minded individuals and organizations throughout the Americas. With the reach and experience of the POA network, E&C has the potential to reach thousands of beneficiaries throughout the region each year and foster enduring mutual understanding.

The E&C Program is a gateway to building long-term impactful partnerships among individuals, communities, and organizations in the U.S. and LAC through program components and their integrated support. POA is uniquely positioned to continue successful implementation, given the widespread POA network. The perspectives of POA members in the planning, recruitment, selection, and implementation promote wider involvement from the network and more support for

locally led solutions to solve the Hemisphere's challenges (*Annex A – Letters of Support*).

> *"The scope of our project expanded significantly, from working with only youth to also working with seniors and university students. I was very pleased that we were able to connect with much more of the community."*
>
> *– Robin McCall (North Carolina, U.S. to La Paz, Bolivia)*

Individual Self-Designed Exchanges

Individual Self-Designed Exchanges will support up to four (4 inbound/outbound person-to-person exchanges that will directly support ECA initiatives. Exchange goals must be aligned with program priorities based on shared ECA and POA areas mentioned above.

Through the POA network, applicants connect with hosts in advance and jointly design trip goals and agendas based on shared interests and resources. U.S. applicants may propose exchanges with one or more hosting Partners Chapters or organizational members in 31 eligible countries, while applicants from Latin America and the Caribbean (LAC) may propose exchanges with 37 Chapters or organizational members across the United States. This reciprocal exchange model strengthens U.S. leadership, expands opportunities for collaboration, and advances the America First agenda by ensuring that American expertise, innovation, and values drive hemispheric partnerships and mutual prosperity.

POA will continue to work with ECA to adjust and define priority themes and objectives. Participants experience cultural immersion with trusted homestays arranged by the host POA Chapter or organization, responsible for some meals and other travel-related costs. Each Individual Self-Designed Exchange agenda must be seven (7) to 10 days in length, excluding international travel, and include time for in-person orientation and cultural acclimation and debrief. Agendas are built collaboratively prior to travel to meet exchange program objectives and allow participants to meet with multiple communities, professionals, government officials, and private sector groups. Benefits to this exchange arrangement include personalized and deepened professional growth leading to sustained cross-cultural relationships and projects (*Annex B - Sample Documents*).

Individual Self-Designed Exchanges

Administration

POA will cover international airfare, per diem, and visa fees. Trip reports, required 30 days post-travel, provide an opportunity for participants to reflect on their experience, engage in follow-on activities, and provide comments to further enhance learnings from the program. Upon completion of all travel, E&C will invite the cohort for a debrief session to discuss experiences and learnings and learn about alumni opportunities. POA will also promote the program's project funding component for alumni to continue collaboration with their host community. POA has a contingency plan (*Annex C*) in the case that health or safety concerns result in exchanges no longer taking place in person. This may involve modifying the budget, expanding the exchange timeline, and adjusting trip plans.

Application, Review, and Onboarding Process

Application

POA will facilitate one open application cycle during the grant period to receive, review, and select Individual Self-Designed Exchanges in coordination with program alumni, network members, and ECA. Applicants can apply in English, Spanish, or Portuguese.

Review Process

POA will reach out to a variety of audiences for both travel applications, as well as to review proposals. Reviewers will receive orientation, and all sensitive information will be hidden from

reviewers to increase fair reviews. Selection begins through an open and transparent process with an eligibility review by POA, followed by feedback collection from a review committee. This committee comprises program alumni and POA community members to ensure continued engagement and representation from potential communities. For inbound participants, POA will evaluate English proficiency to ensure compliance with J-1 visa requirements. For exchange participants, review criteria include using Specific, Measurable, Achievable, Relevant, and Time-bound (SMART) goals, clear ties to program priorities, the capacity for the participant to share and receive knowledge, as well as clear impact and follow-on plans (*Annex B – Sample Documents*). In addition to the general requirements, all self-design program applicants must submit a draft agenda and invitation letter(s) from their host(s). Once reviewed, POA will translate all necessary applicant materials into English and send them to ECA and then to relevant Public Affairs Sector (PAS) teams for final approval. POA will notify and inform all applicants of their application status. Unsuccessful applicants who are not awarded will receive feedback, upon request, outlining why their application was not approved.

Onboarding

POA will support ECA and PAS in the Exchange Visitor (J-1 visa) process and ensure that all participants comply with the terms of their visas, as outlined in 22 CFR 62. POA will also register all travelers for Accident and Sickness Program for Exchanges (ASPE) coverage. POA's travel agency, Travel Leaders Corporate, was competitively selected and contracted to comply with U.S. government travel regulations. POA will work with participants to finalize travel plans and purchase airfare.

Group, Pre-designed Exchanges

Group exchanges offer an enriching experience designed to cultivate community, foster cross-cultural understanding, support citizen diplomacy, and promote personal and professional growth. By promoting U.S. leadership in citizen diplomacy and strengthening hemispheric partnerships, these exchanges directly advance the America First agenda by ensuring that American

values, expertise, and innovation shape cross-cultural collaboration and foster long-term prosperity. Designed for two (2) groups totaling 16 participants, traveling to or from the United States, for seven (7) to 10 days, excluding international travel days. Structured around thematic areas aligned with ECA's priorities and POA's mission, the programs ensure a meaningful experience, allowing participants to delve deep into specific topics relevant to their personal and professional aspirations.

Group exchanges emphasize the creation of a community cohort, traveling and undergoing the program together, fostering a supportive and collaborative environment, thus enhancing the overall exchange experience. Destinations will be determined after a selection process, and agendas may include Washington, DC. As with Individual Self-Designed Exchanges, participants are accommodated in hotels or homestays organized by POA members, allowing participants to continue experiencing cultural immersion while focusing on the program content, networking, and cultural experiences. Funding for group exchange facilitation is available to POA Chapters and premium organizational members throughout the U.S. and LAC. Below outlines the responsibilities of POA and the hosting Chapter(s) or organization:

Phase	Facilitating Chapter/Organization	Partners of the Americas (POA)
Pre-Exchange	• Design and lead local pre-departure orientation • Promote opportunity locally • Collaborate on general virtual orientation	• Lead participant promotion and selection process • Lead general virtual orientation for all participants
During Exchange	• Provide housing, meals, and local transport • Provide on-the-ground health and safety support • Facilitate agenda and submit progress reports • Share social media content	• Purchase international flights • Oversee J-1 visa process (U.S. bound) and ASPE • Provide incidentals stipend • Support coordination of D.C. segment
Post-Exchange	• Lead local debrief(s) • Develop alumni follow-up plans • Submit final report and success story	• Lead program-wide debriefs • Facilitate alumni platform access • Collect participant and facilitator reporting

Exchange Participant Support

Orientation

POA will facilitate a virtual pre-departure orientation to discuss exchange requirements and resources available including ASPE and J-1 visa guidance, provide advice, share alumni opportunities, connect participants, and answer questions on their upcoming cultural immersion

experience. POA will invite a former exchange participant to support the pre-departure orientation, who will provide personalized advice for travelers. POA will also share an orientation packet with relevant information as a supplement to the pre-departure orientation (*Annex B – Sample Documents*).

Upon arrival, participants will have a second, on-site orientation with their host Chapter(s)/organization(s) to review goals and activities for the exchange and local emergency procedures and participate in welcome orientation and activities. At this point, a member from the POA team will check in with each participant to ensure that their arrival was satisfactory. POA will support hosts with thorough pre-departure and arrival orientations by providing an orientation guide template for hosts. Topics will include local health and safety information, cultural recommendations, and cross-cultural tips.

Debrief and Closeout

After returning home, POA staff will ensure participants had safe return trips and inform them of the next steps. POA will facilitate a debrief session to reflect on lessons learned, challenges, successes, and next steps. Participants will submit a report detailing their experiences, changes in perceptions, and feedback. POA will continue to highlight the stories of exchange participants on social media and encourage networking with fellow E&C and other alumni of U.S.-funded exchange programs. As part of the closeout process, recipients will register with the International Exchange Alumni network and be encouraged to connect and interact with other ECA alumni who work on similar issues as well as to seek other opportunities for continued global engagement through the U.S. Department of State and PAS abroad.

Community-Led Projects

Community-led projects support initiatives that align with the program's objectives and ECA's strategic goals stated above. Activities may include developing a series of learning exchanges, building educational opportunities and resources, or organizing community-building activities. Funding is available to POA Chapters and premium organizational members throughout the U.S.

and LAC to promote collaboration to solve the Hemisphere's toughest challenges. All activities must include a component based outside of the U.S. and goals must be aligned with program priorities.

Subawards - Group Pre-Designed Exchanges and Community-Led Projects

Application, Review, and Onboarding Process

Figure 3:
Sub-Award Example Timeline

Group pre-designed exchanges and community-led projects will be managed as sub-awards. Prior to the application launch, POA will work with ECA to finalize formal Requests for Applications (RFA) for the two (2) funding opportunities, which will be shared publicly in English, Spanish, Portuguese for potential applicants to understand the complete requirements, expectations, and review criteria (*Annex B – Sample Documents*).

Application and Promotion

Sub-awards will be selected in one cycle, promoted through an informational session, newsletters, email campaigns, social media, Chapter meetings, and the POA website. POA will also share announcements with ECA for further reach.

Through the sub-award management platform, applicants can apply in English, Spanish, and Portuguese and reviewers will review in the relevant language, and provide scores and feedback to each application section. At least three reviewers will review each application to ensure transparency, reduce potential variances across reviewer scores and feedback, and include different perspectives. Proposed projects will be sent in English to ECA for approval and to relevant Embassies for their input. All applicants will receive notification of the final decision. Those not awarded will receive information, upon request, outlining why the proposal was not selected.

Onboarding and Support

Those selected for funding will receive orientation and guidance on requirements, promotion,

monitoring and evaluation, communications, etc. to ensure compliance with USG funding requirements and participant capacity bridging. POA will arrange the contracts and payments for the start of the awards so that teams can implement their projects immediately. Implementors must submit narrative and cost share reporting. Throughout the award, recipients will regularly meet with POA staff for check-ins on programmatic questions, concerns, and success, as well as connect with other implementors for learning circles which are mentioned in INNOVATIONS and focus on bridging capacities as defined by implementors.

Program Workplan and Marketing

Workplan

POA developed a Work Plan (Annex D) to demonstrate the overlapping timelines of core program activities and stakeholder involvement. This includes participant recruitment, selection, orientation, implementation, debriefing, and alumni engagement. The Work Plan states proposed core periods in which POA will consult ECA and PAS on significant program decisions such as awardee selection.

Marketing & Communications

POA will implement a multi-channel communications strategy—including social media, newsletters, email campaigns, press releases, webinars, alumni stories, and the POA website—to promote the program, recruit applicants, and share impact (*Annex E – Communications and Marketing Plan*). Communications will span the full program cycle: launch, application, implementation, and closeout. Storytelling will remain central, showcasing participant experiences and alumni outcomes to strengthen engagement.

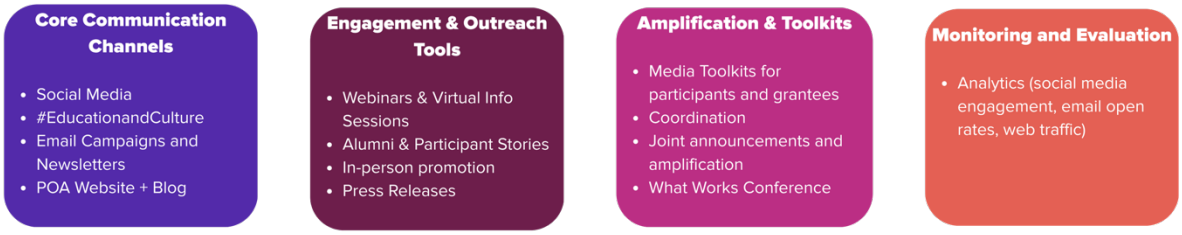
POA will share program announcements and success stories with ECA and relevant U.S. Embassies for amplification, coordinating press releases and outreach activities. Webinars and virtual sessions will invite public participation, highlight application steps, and describe exchange opportunities, with invitations extended to ECA and Embassy staff. Participants and grantees will receive a media toolkit to support local dissemination, including sample posts, templates, and tips for sharing stories and engaging media outlets. Communications efforts will adhere to ECA branding

and attribution requirements.

America250

POA will explore opportunities to celebrate the United States' Semiquincentennial (America250) through its E&C programming. Exchange participants will be invited to share reflections on how their program experiences connect to 250 years of American values and leadership. POA will also promote the value of civic engagement through volunteering, aligning with AmericaGives' mission to build on America's legacy of giving back and inspiring a renewed culture of service for decades to come. This will be done by promoting member-led volunteer initiatives and volunteer challenges. Finally, participants will be invited to share their work at POA's annual What Works Conference to further spotlight program impact and foster cross-regional learning.

Figure 4:
Marketing and Communications Components



Collaboration with ECA/PAS

Along with the POA E&C team, stakeholders include various POA teams (communications, community & volunteer engagement, and finance & administration), ECA, and the U.S. Embassy PAS in the countries participating in E&C. POA will implement a strategic communications plan ensuring adequate messaging and use of communications and outreach channels (*Annex E – Communications and Marketing Plan*). POA will collaborate with ECA to effectively communicate the key activities and impact and ensure that program materials and marketing strategy comply with the Communications Guidance for ECA Recipient Organizations. Additionally, POA will establish regular recurring meetings with ECA to provide updates on progress.

POA will work with ECA to schedule meetings with PAS, embassies, and consulates to present E&C and strengthen awareness and knowledge, including providing a one-page document (*Annex E*) that contains details on POA and E&C for their use in program promotion, selection, and continued involvement with grantees. Marketing and communication synergies between the POA Chapters and U.S. Embassy Public and Cultural Affairs Officers are mutually beneficial for promoting the program and leveraging follow-on resources and support.

Alumni Engagement

POA considers exchange programs merely the beginning of long-term engagement. The network of POA allows exchange participants and sub-award recipients to have additional support and engagement past the program's end, aiding in sustainable impact. Pre-existing relationships and communities associated with POA Chapters across the region provide an opportunity for alumni to continue growing their impact, network and reach beyond their award period. After being funded, awardees do not disappear but remain engaged in a network of professionals with a shared passion and commitment to continued growth.

POA also supports the alumni experience through ongoing opportunities such as connecting them with other volunteers and institutions to support their work, engaging in regional

events and mutual interest groups, and sharing their stories on social media. POA shares information with exchange participants about their alumni resources such as Alumni.state.gov prior to applying, upon approval of their applications, in the orientation packet prior to travel, and on the completion of their exchange.

POA engages alumni in E&C through various volunteer opportunities to support the planning, recruitment, selection, and implementation processes. This aims to benefit both alumni and the program, promoting civic engagement in their local and global communities and participant-led programming. Following their participation, POA will invite alumni to a debrief session to network with recent fellow alumni and learn about their resources and options to stay involved. Further, POA will invite alumni of all components of the program to serve as (1) application reviewers, (2) alumni panelists for workshops, (3) orientation support to provide advice to new recipients, and (4) content creators for social media and blog posts on their impact and advice for future applicants.

Lessons Learned, Improved Productivity, and Innovations

Lessons Learned

POA integrates monitoring and evaluation throughout the lifecycle of each iteration of the program to receive feedback, build a sense of agency amongst community members and alumni, and guide continuations and adaptations to the program.

Group Exchange Facilitation

Based on feedback received from applicants, participants, and hosts on the difficulty of connecting with each other to apply and build meaningful agendas, in FY2022 POA designed facilitated its first group exchange through E&C. Through this, POA removed the need for applicants to find their own hosts and create their own agendas and streamlined the application

process resulting in a record-high of 118 applications for ten (10) spots. After the program's success, in FY2023, POA further innovated by incorporating Chapter-leadership into group exchanges, hiring a Chapter President as a consultant to design and facilitate an exchange in her community in collaboration with POA. In FY24, POA has further expanded this to open group exchange facilitation to all Chapters and organizational members to foster community-led exchanges. FY2025 will continue with this formatting to engage more communities in exchanges.

Virtual Exchange Adaptability

POA has the proven capacity to deliver and pivot from in-person to virtual exchanges. During the COVID-19 pandemic, POA rapidly adopted digital platforms—such as Whova, Zoom, and WhatsApp—to maintain high-quality programming. These tools now complement the in-person experience by enabling pre-departure trainings, hemispheric workshops, virtual networking hours, and post-exchange reflection sessions and storytelling. These innovations have extended impact and engagement beyond the ten-day exchange. POA remains prepared to deliver meaningful virtual alternatives through interactive online courses, cross-border collaboration, and problem-solving sessions. Leveraging its regional network, POA ensures virtual activities foster lasting connections, while advancing foreign policy goals.

Innovations

Learning Circles – Goal 1

As an innovation to Goal 1 to strengthen the professional skills of emerging and established U.S. foreign leaders and organizations through project funding and people-to-people exchanges, POA will integrate learning circles to support applicants and awardees in their professional growth. Based on a needs-based analysis, topics would include grant writing, social media, volunteer engagement, and fundraising. Additionally, POA plans to collect baseline and endline measurements to strengthen reporting and evidence of impact.

Project Management Capacity Building – Goal 2

To support Goal 2 to support safer, stronger, and more prosperous communities across

the Western Hemisphere by increasing meaningful participation of applicants, alumni, and program partners throughout program planning and implementation, POA will train and empower POA Chapters in planning, recruitment, and implementation processes to build their project management experience.

Expanded Use of Technology

To improve efficiency of sub-award management, POA began to use a flexible and data-driven grants management platform in 2022. This platform centralizes all relevant programmatic resources and steps, as well as allows applicants to manage their own materials across the lifecycle of their award. In 2025, POA is expanding use of the platform to integrate all E&C programming for consistent systems and improved processes, which will support improved communication and transparency with all parties.

Institutional Capacity & Management Plan

Institutional Capacity

POA has over 60 years of experience fostering volunteerism and international community development in LAC, building strong relationships, and engaging grassroots volunteers and public, private, and civil society sector leaders to affect change in local communities and across borders (*Annex F*). POA is uniquely positioned to continue implementing E&C due to its significant experience managing complex, multiphase, and sustainable social/community development programs as well as a vast network of Chapters, organizational members, and strategic partners. As of 2024, POA managed an annual portfolio of approximately US$27 million of USG-funded programs (*Annex A*), including the U.S. Agency for International Development, the U.S. Department of Labor, the U.S. Department of Agriculture, and the U.S. Department of State. POA currently implements a portfolio of four (4) U.S. Department of State programs, including the 100,000 Strong in the Americas initiative, Mexico Migration Messaging, and Mexico United 2026. By connecting farmers and local businesses to critical resources and skillsets, and by

strengthening local economies across Latin America and the Caribbean, POA advances American economic and security interests—reducing the drivers of illegal immigration and promoting stability that benefits the United States and its partners.

For over 50 years, POA has managed exchange programs that send as many as 300 participants per year between the U.S. and LAC. Past programs have included the American Fellows Program, Professional Fellows Program, and various sports diplomacy exchanges. These successful programs demonstrate how POA's committed and dynamic network supports cultural exchange at the grassroots level with community leaders, educators, professionals, and youth, fostering sustained engagement and partnerships long after the program ends. POA adheres to all DOS contract regulations and reporting requirements by possessing the capacity to build, adjust, and streamline management systems to ensure sound planning before, during, and after exchange programs and project implementation. POA also maintains its ability to remain flexible in program design and adapt to various circumstances while ensuring that it meets intended goals, such as adding the group exchange component as a flexible adaptation to meet POA's target exchange participant numbers.

POA and its international network of over 75 Chapters and organizational members are equipped to act as social accountability partners, ensuring innovative ideas and programs that resonate with community needs by creating opportunities for dialogue with local stakeholders. POA's network also includes higher education institutions and government entities that collaborate on various programs such as educational exchanges and community initiatives. The vast reach and strength of the network allows POA to remain flexible and to recruit participants, host organizations, and collaborators working in key priority areas while maintaining a focus on the broader objectives of increasing understanding and building skills of both participants and organizations. POA's staff, program, and volunteer presence extends across 37 U.S. states and 15 countries in LAC. POA's strategic plan for 2024-2030 focuses on significant growth and strengthening of the network to increase opportunities for international exchange and capacity

building by utilizing innovative techniques, technology, and strategic partnerships with other organizations working with various populations in the Americas.

Key Personnel

POA staff (*Annex G – CV of Proposed Personnel*) are responsible for ensuring that exchanges and projects meet program objectives and sustain impact, as well as providing professional and responsive support to awardees. This requires qualified staff with the necessary combination of education and experience to implement quality programs.

The **Associate Program Director (AD)**, Maia Moore, will be responsible for a) financial and programmatic management; b) supervising staff and managing all aspects of day-to-day activities; c) donor relations and maintaining regular communication with ECA and PAS; and d) ensuring program compliance with regulations. She will manage day-to-day activities, including leading the proposal review process. Ms. Moore will serve as the primary point of contact with DOS for all technical and administrative matters and lead semi-annual and final program reports. Working closely with the Finance and Administration (F&A) Unit, she will ensure that program activities comply with U.S. Government and U.S. Department of State financial management procedures and that costs are allowable and classified in accordance with U.S. Generally Accepted Accounting Principles (GAAP). In addition to the Associate Program Director, E&C will be supported by Finance and Administration, Communications, and Monitoring and Evaluation staff.

Performance Monitoring Plan (PMP)

POA will develop a robust, cohesive, well-coordinated results-based monitoring, evaluation and learning approach to measure the project's progress related to the three program goals. Overall management of E&C activities will be the responsibility of the program's Associate Director. The AD will lead the development of the PMP with a detailed outline covering data collection and management standards, processes, tools, and methods. POA has deployed a

cloud-based tool to collect, manage, and share project data with the relevant stakeholders seamlessly.

A PMP (*Annex H*) and a Work Plan (*Annex D*) describe program activities and a timeline for reaching targets. Biannual reporting to ECA will highlight progress towards achieving these outcomes. The PMP is modeled after ECA's Monitoring, Evaluation, Learning, and Innovation (MELI) Unit and MODE indicators recommended in the solicitation (four demographic and 16 performance) and will enable POA to routinely track and report project performance, facilitating collaboration between POA, ECA, program participants, and other stakeholders. This promotes learning through planned activities, established processes, and close monitoring, with adjustments to strategies and approaches throughout. Performance Evaluation will be guided by the questions in the PMP under the ECA objectives 1, 2, 3, 4, and 8, aligned with E&C Goals, as outlined above.

POA will employ various tools to assess performance indicators, collect both quantitative and qualitative data, and assess the degree to which the program is meeting its goals. Formally, Group Exchange Facilitation, Community-Led Project, and exchange participant data will be collected via the Zengine by WizeHive grants management platform. MODE indicator data will be collected via MELI's Qualtrics survey to ensure streamlined reporting. Additionally, POA will leverage other tools such as Mentimeter, MicrosoftForms, and Zoom surveys to collect short term and immediate feedback from all stakeholders including applicants and volunteers. As needed, POA will carry out additional studies and evaluations to investigate learning questions that emerge throughout implementation.

Learning & Adapting Strategy

POA will collect qualitative/quantitative information to support learning and adaptation of program implementation strategies based on generating knowledge from program experience to apply adaptative decision-making and improve program outcomes. Specifically, POA will implement the following:

- **Pause and Reflect Sessions** with ECA will be carried out at two levels. In Activity-level sessions, POA will *internally* review program data, identify trends, analyze achievements, and collect feedback contributing to better planning and evidence-based decision-making. During Implementing-level sessions, POA will discuss information from Activity-level sessions with ECA to identify key issues/practices affecting implementation.
- **Dissemination of Lessons Learned** will take place through biannual program briefs that share performance data and summarize program accomplishments, challenges, and recommendations. In addition to biannual reports, POA will share periodic M&E data with ECA to raise program awareness with its stakeholders.

After learning activities, POA will carry out a process for adjusting in response to new information and changes in the context. Collaboration between POA's leadership, E&C staff, and the Monitoring and Evaluation Unit will create opportunities to identify innovative ideas and solutions to adapt program implementation.

Annexes

Annex A	Letters of Support
Annex B	Sample Forms and Documents
Annex C	Contingency Plan
Annex D	Workplan
Annex E	Marketing and Communications Plan
Annex F	Past Performance References
Annex G	CVs of Proposed Staff
Annex H	Monitoring and Evaluation Performance (PMP)